# The Anything Box

## By Zenna Henderson

**DAVE:** *(angrily)* Teacher? She looks!

**TEACHER:** Who looks?

**DAVE:** Sue-Lynn. She looks and looks.

**TEACHER:** At you?

**DAVE:** "She looks at her desk and tells lies. She says she can see.

**TEACHER:** Can see what?

**DAVE:** Anything It's her anything box! She can see anything she wants too.

## INTRODUCTION

*It began as a game, a way of getting attention, but soon it became so much more. It became her very existence. You see, circumstances beyond her control tore her world apart. Her Anything Box became her way of connecting to the past, of re-living a happier, safer time. It became her comfort, her sanity. Disappear with me into Sue-Lynn's Anything Box by Zenna Henderson.*

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**TEACHER:** I suppose it was about the second week of school that I noticed Sue-Lynn particularly. She had finished her paper-far ahead of the others as usual- and was sitting at her table, She had her thumbs touching in front of her on the table and her fingers curving as though they held something between them. She was looking completely absorbed. Her face was relaxed and happy.

I saw that she spent most of her free time staring at the table between her hands. She hurried through papers and then lost herself in looking. Several times after that I wandered to the back of the room. She saw or felt me coming, and her hand disposed of the evidence. Only once I thought I caught a glimmer of something, I started to
wonder about Sue-Lynn. I watched her on the playground. That only confused me more.

Each time before she joined the rush to our door, her hand would sketch a gesture to her pocket. I began to worry about Sue-Lynn. Maybe this was a disturbance that *was* more fundamental than the usual run-of-

the-mill that I had met up with. Maybe a child can smile a soft, contended smile and still have little maggots of madness flourishing somewhere inside. Maybe she ***does*** have an Anything Box. Maybe she ***is*** looking at something precious. Who am I to say no to anything like that?

What could you see in an anything box? Heart's desire? I felt my own heart lurch just a little the next time Sue-Lynn's hands curved. If it was ***her*** anything box, I wouldn't be able to see my heart's desire in it. Or would I? Then I felt a small presence at my elbow and turned to meet Sue-Lynn's wide eyes.

**SUE-LYNN:** *(whispering)* Teacher? You see my box teacher? It's my Anything Box!

**TEACHER:** *(To Sue-Lynn)* Oh my, may I hold it? *(to audience)* I took the squareness from her carefully. My tenderness showing in my fingers and face. And I received weight and substance and actuality. *(She looks inside and in awe, describes what she sees)* ***I was running barefoot through the whispering grass. My heart outstripping my flying feet and melted with a rush of delight into warmness as his arms-*** *(to Sue-Lynn)* It's beautiful. It's wonderful, Sue-Lynn. Where did you get it?

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**SUE-LYNN:** It's mine!

**TEACHER:** A night or so later when I leaned over my noon-drenched windowsill. I remembered the Anything Box. Could I make one for myself? Could I square off this aching waiting, this outreach, this silent cry inside me and make it into an Anything Box? I freed my hands and brought them together framing a part of the horizon's darkness. I stared into the empty square until my eyes watered.

Sue-Lynn came to school sleepy-eyed and quiet. She didn't finish any of her work and feel asleep during rest time. The next day Sue-Lynn burst into tears and slapped Dave!

Sue-Lynn! I gathered Dave up and took Sue-Lynn's hand. In the shocked silence of the room, we stumbled over to the Isolation Bench. Seating herself, she leaned her head into the corner and sobbed quietly.

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*(to Dave)* What did you do?

**DAVE:** I only said robber daughter. It said so in the paper. My mama said her daddy's a robber.

**TEACHER:** I kept my eyes on Sue-Lynn for the next half hour as I busied myself with the class. Her sobs soon stopped and I knew she was taking comfort in her Anything Box.

That afternoon I looked up from my reading group, to catch Sue-Lynn's frightened eyes. She looked down at her empty hands. Then she darted to the Isolation corner and reached under the chair. She went back to her seat slowly. For the first time, She-Lynn had to go get the Anything Box.

She sank into her Anything Box at every opportunity. And always, if she had put it away somewhere, she had to go back for it. She roused more and more reluctantly from these waking dreams, and there finally came a day where I had to shake her to waken her.

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And before our horrified eyes, she toppled sideways off the chair; lay limp on the green tile, one hand still around something. I pried her fingers loose. I carried her down to the nurse's room and she opened her eyes. Her hands jerked protestingly in mine.

*(to Sue-Lynn)* Your Anything Box is just for fun! You mustn't think it's real. It's only play.

**SUE-LYNN:** *(crying)* No! No! *(she frantically looks for her Anything Box)* Where is it? Give it back to me, teacher! Where did you put it?

**TEACHER:** There is no Anything Box. It's just imagination. It doesn't exist.

**SUE-LYNN:** It does! And I almost got in… into my Anything Box. *My* daddy's there… *My* daddy's there… I want my daddy.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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